



## Boundary Spanning Activities and the Multidisciplinary Team Process: Characteristics Affecting School Psychological Consultation

George H. Amedore & Howard M. Knoff

**To cite this article:** George H. Amedore & Howard M. Knoff (1993) Boundary Spanning Activities and the Multidisciplinary Team Process: Characteristics Affecting School Psychological Consultation, *Journal of Educational and Psychological Consultation*, 4:4, 343-356, DOI: [10.1207/s1532768xjepc0404\\_4](https://doi.org/10.1207/s1532768xjepc0404_4)

**To link to this article:** [https://doi.org/10.1207/s1532768xjepc0404\\_4](https://doi.org/10.1207/s1532768xjepc0404_4)



Published online: 08 Jun 2010.



Submit your article to this journal 



Article views: 27



View related articles 

# Boundary Spanning Activities and the Multidisciplinary Team Process: Characteristics Affecting School Psychological Consultation

George H. Amedore

*Saratoga Springs City School District  
Saratoga Springs, NY*

Howard M. Knoff

*University of South Florida*

To test some of the social and organizational psychology underpinnings of boundary spanning theory, the consultative, boundary spanning activities of 27 New York State school psychologists within their special education multidisciplinary teams were studied. More specifically, the relation between boundary spanning and task uncertainty, role specification, degree of professional training and continuing activity, size of organization, and available organizational resources was investigated. The results indicated that boundary spanning was significantly related to perceived task uncertainty. The implications of these results were discussed, and future research efforts needed to further differentiate this important construct were suggested.

Boundary spanning activities occur when school personnel cross the formal or informal professional or organizational boundaries that exist in their work environments to interact with other professionals, resources, or agencies. For school personnel, these activities proceed either (a) within a school or school district so that school personnel can work more efficiently and/or increase job productivity or satisfaction or (b) outside

the school district so that community agencies and other resources can facilitate the educational and mental health responsibilities of the system (Aldrich & Herker, 1977; Leifer & Delbecq, 1978; Tushman & Scanlan, 1981). For specific school personnel, boundary spanning activities are defined by their profession, training, and job descriptions and the specific roles and circumstances within those job descriptions. Organizationally, boundary spanning is a complex process that also is affected by the clarity of a school or school district's mission or goals and a number of interdependently related variables, including the district's organizational complexity and size; its personnel plan, policies, and job descriptions; its organizational climate; its behavioral norms and expectations; and the differential levels of training, skill, and ongoing professionalism by its employees (Aldrich & Herker, 1977; Downey & Slocum, 1975; Leifer & Delbecq, 1978).

Within the schools, school psychologists are boundary spanning professionals (Schmuck, 1990). They consult with administrators and teachers in the schools across a wide variety of psychoeducational and mental health problems and issues, they work outside of the schools with children and their parents, and they interact with community-based professionals regarding comprehensive and integrated services to children and adolescents (Knoff & Batsche, 1990). Significantly, although consumer satisfaction with school psychological services increases as boundary spanning activities increase (Hughes, 1979; Kahl & Fine, 1978; Schowengert, Fine, & Poggio, 1976; Senft & Snider, 1980), we still do not fully understand the organizational or professional variables that impact and relate to increased boundary spanning activities for school psychologists (Illback & Maher, 1984; Yoshida, Maher, & Hawryluk, 1984). This information might explain why some school psychologists are restricted to certain job activities (e.g., special education testing) whereas others are engaged, for example, in more comprehensive and preventive service delivery. This information also might help school psychologists to identify and address those district-related variables that result in increased boundary spanning activities as well as assist district leaders and others to understand those characteristics needed for school psychologists to work most effectively and efficiently with students and staff.

Jerrell (1984) published the only explicitly identified boundary spanning study that targeted school psychologists, a study that involved rural school psychologists and their superintendents in western Pennsylvania. In this study, boundary spanning activities consisted primarily of working and consulting with local mental health and child welfare agencies, conducting inservices in the community on mental health related issues, and giving talks to local parent and community service

groups. Survey results indicated that those school psychologists who engaged in more boundary spanning activities reported greater influence in their organization's definition of their professional role and higher job satisfaction. Further, from the superintendents' perspectives, school psychologists' boundary spanning activities appeared to increase when the community was described as unstable, fluctuating, and lacking in external resources. Although this study suggests that school psychologists' boundary spanning activities increase in response to environmental uncertainty, a great deal more research is needed both in this area and in other areas related to school psychological practice.

One area that should be investigated for its boundary spanning implications is the multidisciplinary, special education staffing team mandated by the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) legislation. Already, we know that school psychologists spend the vast majority of their professional time performing special education assessment or consultation tasks that are ultimately related to the multidisciplinary team (Goldwasser, Meyers, Christenson, & Graden, 1983; Smith, 1984), and that these teams vary in (a) the efficiency and effectiveness of group process (Kaiser & Woodman, 1985; Maher & Pfeiffer, 1983); (b) the differential influence, participation, and satisfaction of individual team members (Knoff, 1983; Yoshida, Fenton, Maxwell, & Kaufman, 1978); (c) team members' individual knowledge and understanding of their legal mandates (Yoshida, 1983); and (d) the degree to which they increase professional territoriality and role confusion (Kaiser & Woodman, 1985; Wallace, 1976). Yet, we do not know how specific organizational variables that relate both the school system in general and the multidisciplinary team in particular affect the school psychologist and his or her boundary spanning activities in the context of the multidisciplinary team. This is the focus of this study that attempted to build on Jerrell's (1984) investigation of environmental uncertainty and boundary spanning activity, including other organizational variables of interest.

Beyond the school psychology literature, the relation between boundary spanning and a number of other variables have been researched extensively in the social and organizational psychology literature (Aldrich & Herker, 1977; Downey & Slocum, 1975; Illback & Maher, 1984; Katz & Kahn, 1978; Leifer & Delbecq, 1978). These variables include task uncertainty, role specification, degree of professional training and continuing activity, size of organization, and available organizational resources. Briefly, boundary spanning activities have been positively related to environmental uncertainty, task uncertainty, degree of professional training and continuing professional activity, and size and wealth of the organization, and negatively related to role specification.

These same relations are expected for school psychologists working within their special education, multidisciplinary staffing teams.

## METHOD

### Subjects

School psychologists assigned to the district-level multidisciplinary team from all 57 small city school districts located throughout New York were potential subjects in this study. In New York, at the time of this study, all *building-level* multidisciplinary teams made recommendations for all referred students to a single *district-level* team that made all final placement and eligibility decisions. The school psychologists in this study delivered services in their own individual school buildings, but they also were assigned to represent their colleagues at the district, multidisciplinary team (MDT) level. A small city school district for this study was defined by the New York State Education Department criteria and described as those districts with pupil enrollments from 1,256 to 10,580 students ( $M = 4,608$  students) and real property wealths (based on a full valuation to resident weighted average daily attendance ratio) of \$41,536 to \$322,643 ( $M = \$87,114$ ). The district-level MDTs included (but were not limited to) the following members: a certified teacher or administrator of special education, a school psychologist, a physician, a teacher of special education, a parent of a handicapped child from the community, and the parent whose child was being referred for possible placement and programming. Two pilot studies to develop and evaluate the study's boundary spanning questionnaire were completed with three of these districts, leaving 54 districts (and district-level, MDT school psychologists) available for data collection.

### Procedure

Superintendents for all 54 remaining districts received an invitation to participate in this study; 34 districts indicated availability and interest. These 34 districts were deemed representative of the total small city district population with pupil enrollments ranging from 1,256 to 10,580 students ( $M = 4,841$  students) and real property wealths ranging from \$41,536 to \$145,557 ( $M = \$74,529$ ). Each district's MDT chairperson was sent a boundary spanning questionnaire that was distributed to the school psychologist who also participated on the district-level MDT. Each school psychologist completed the questionnaire independently and returned it directly to the first author using the provided addressed envelope. Completion of the questionnaire took from 20 to 30 min.

Ultimately, 27 school psychologists (50% of the 54 possible participating districts) returned their boundary spanning questionnaires. Descriptively, there were 16 male and 11 female school psychologists within this sample with ages ranging from 27 to 65 years old ( $M = 41.14$ ,  $SD = 8.59$ ). None of these school psychologists held the doctoral degree, 22 (81.5%) held an EdS or a 60 graduate credit hr advanced degree, and 5 (18.5%) held a master's degree. Finally, these school psychologists averaged 5.41 years of experience ( $SD = 6.32$ ) as MDT members, and none of the school psychologists were serving as the MDT chair.

### **Instrumentation**

The Boundary Spanning Questionnaire (BSQ), used as the primary data-collection tool in this study, is a 30-item self-report questionnaire designed to collect data on three facets of boundary spanning and seven independent variables identified in the organizational psychology literature as potential boundary spanning correlates.<sup>1</sup> Compiled by adapting and integrating other researchers' empirically based and validated boundary spanning questionnaires (Aldrich & Herker, 1977; Hage & Aiken, 1967; Leifer, 1975; Tushman & Scanlan, 1981; Van De Ven & Ferry, 1980) to school and MDT settings, the BSQ depended predominantly on the work of Leifer (1975) for the Boundary Spanning Activity and Perceived Environmental Uncertainty variables and Van De Ven and Ferry (1980) for the Perceived Task Uncertainty, Perceived Role Specification, and Role Professionalism variables. Validity for the various BSQ scales has been established primarily through principal components factor analyses, with item loadings ranging from .48 to .89 across the six factors, and through content and concurrent validity studies that utilized expert reviews and correlations with parallel measures, respectively (Leifer, 1975; Leifer & Huber, 1977; Van De Ven & Ferry, 1980). Reliability for the BSQ scales has focused predominantly on internal consistency and has been established, within expected ranges, using coefficient alpha data. These data have been revisited and reconfirmed during the pilot testing of the BSQ (see the following). In all, there appears to be sufficient psychometric support for the specific variables of the BSQ, and they are defined as follows:

#### ***Dependent Variables***

***Boundary Spanning Activity.*** This variable focuses on the behavior of individuals who are involved in the process of interprofessional

<sup>1</sup>The Boundary Spanning Questionnaire is available from Howard M. Knoff on request.



consultation and communication as it relates to multidisciplinary referrals and staffings. This process has two components: (a) consulting with (i.e., translating and transmitting information to) people within the organization and (b) consulting with (i.e., gathering information from and sending information to) people outside the organization. Thus, the variable Boundary Spanning-Total has two components, boundary spanning-internal and boundary spanning-external. MDT boundary spanning activities are measured by asking how many hours and types of formal and informal consultation interactions (e.g., MDT-related meetings, phone conversations, and other communications) occur in an average week, both within and outside the school organization. These variables are measured by eight BSQ items.

### *Independent Variables*

***Perceived Environmental Uncertainty.*** This variable focuses on the perception of change or uncertainty by individuals within the organization due to demands placed on the organization by other organizations or by people outside, but not inside, their own formal organization. BSQ items related to this variable investigated how often sociological conditions (e.g., resident mobility), economic conditions (e.g., federal and state funding and public support for special education), political conditions (e.g., new federal and state special education regulations), and legal conditions (e.g., new special education court or state rules decisions) were perceived to affect school psychologists' work and decisions within the MDT. Other items investigated the effects of changes in educational philosophy and teaching strategies and methodologies, and how often and how receptive those outside of the school organization were to provide information, support, and resources when needed. This variable is measured by nine BSQ items that describe the aforementioned conditions and ask respondents to rate their occurrence on a 5-point scale from *never* (1) to *very frequently* (5).

***Perceived Task Uncertainty.*** This variable focuses on the degree to which the methods used in task completion are perceived as unpredictable, varied, and nonroutine. Task uncertainty involves *task difficulty* (i.e., the inability to analyze task goals and outcomes and to predict appropriate work methods) and *task validity* (i.e., the number of special education referrals encountered) as undertaken within an organization unit. BSQ items here investigated (a) school psychologists' difficulty in applying state special education definitions and criteria to individual MDT cases such that appropriate placement decisions are made; (b) the difficulty in evaluating these decisions; (c) the frequency and amount of

MDT time involved with difficult cases requiring educational programs that substantially differ from those existing in the school district or those that have no immediate or apparent psychoeducational solutions; and (d) the similarity of the IEP goals and objectives required to address the academic, social, physical, and management needs of all the MDT cases seen. This variable is measured by nine BSQ items. The task difficulty items were rated on 5-point scales that ranged, for example, from *never* (1) to *very frequently* (5), or *very similar* (1) to *very different* (5), depending on the focus of the question. The task variability items were rated on 5-point scales that separated the data requested into defined amounts (e.g., from 1% to 40% or less, or from 5% to 91% or more).

***Perceived Role Specification.*** This variable focuses on the degree to which task group members report that they use and abide by the rules, policies, and procedures specified to coordinate their work activities. BSQ items here investigated how many and how precise the school districts' rules governing the MDT process were, how often they are followed, and how well they relate to the diverse situations that can occur during MDT meetings. This variable is measured by four BSQ items. The items again were organized into 5-point scales that separated the information desired into discrete response sets.

***Role Professionalism.*** This variable is examined by investigating the school psychologist's formal training (i.e., number of graduate credit hours earned in school psychological or related fields) and ongoing professional and continuing education activities (i.e., time per week reading the professional literature; yearly attendance at inservice, workshop, and other seminar programs; membership in local, state, and professional associations). This variable is measured by four BSQ items.

***Size and Real Property Wealth of the School District.*** These two variables were measured by data collected from the New York Department of Education. These two variables were included to further evaluate the organizational research that found increases in boundary spanning activities with increases in district size and wealth. Data for each of these variables were summed together and used as an unweighted score.

### **Pilot Testing with the BSQ**

The BSQ underwent two pilot testings using three of New York's 57 small city school districts and five other New York school districts of comparable size and wealth. Because all of the BSQ's items were drawn



from instruments that had previously been validated (see Leifer, 1975, and Leifer & Huber, 1977, for more detailed information), the pilot testing was completed to ensure that items reworded for the public schools maintained their psychometric integrity. The first pilot test involved an evaluation of the BSQ's content validity by 29 school-based multidisciplinary team members from eight school districts and resulted in the rewording of several items that were considered ambiguous or unclear. Data collected here were qualitatively analyzed with a focus on semantic clarity and effective communication. The second pilot test, completed by 30 different multidisciplinary team members in eight school districts, evaluated the internal consistency and discriminant validity of each BSQ variable using coefficient alpha and correlational statistics, respectively, with the following results for the coefficient alpha statistics: Perceived Environmental Uncertainty, .63; Perceived Task Uncertainty, .58; Role Specification, .72; Role Professionalism, .04; Boundary Spanning (Total), .94. Except for Role Professionalism, these statistics compared favorably to previous research evaluating these boundary spanning constructs (Van De Ven & Ferry, 1980), which established expected coefficient alpha ranges given the breadth of each construct. The low Role Professionalism statistic was not unexpected given research suggesting that this variable was not unitary. This variable was separated into two subset areas, professional training and professional activity (described previously), to explore the possible relation of their individual questions to boundary spanning activity, and it was retained in the larger study to ensure that the pilot test results did not occur due to a statistical artifact or the fact that only eight districts were included.

Relative to discriminant validity, the correlational analyses indicated that each of the five variables correlated moderately with all others but not to such a degree that each variable lost its statistical independence. For example, Perceived Environmental Uncertainty correlated .38 with all other BSQ items, Perceived Task Uncertainty correlated .44, Role Specification correlated .44, and Role Professionalism correlated .46. Both sets of correlations suggest that the internal consistency and discriminant validities, respectively, of the BSQ were acceptable and that no additional adaptations were necessary (Van De Ven & Ferry, 1980). The content validity of the BSQ, as noted previously, was determined during the first pilot testing.

## RESULTS

Data from the BSQ were evaluated through correlational analyses. Descriptive means and standard deviations from individual BSQ items

will not be discussed or described here because the variables identified during the scale's development provide a more parsimonious explanation of the data and results. BSQ means and standard deviations can be found in Table 1.

The intercorrelation matrix, presented in Table 2, consists of 10 variables: the 3 dependent boundary spanning variables (internal, external, and total), the 5 independent BSQ variables (Perceived Environmental Uncertainty, Perceived Task Uncertainty, Perceived Role Specification, Professional Training, and Professional Activity), and the 2 independent school district characteristics (size of district and district wealth). Among the Pearson correlation coefficients contrasting these 10 variables, there were eight significant correlations. The three most significant correlations demonstrated the expected interrelations between the three boundary spanning variables: Boundary Spanning-Total was significantly related to both boundary spanning-internal ( $r = .91, p < .005$ ) and boundary spanning-external ( $r = .72, p < .005$ ), whereas boundary spanning-internal was significantly related to boundary spanning-external ( $r = .53, p < .005$ ). Three significant correlations existed between the three boundary spanning variables and Task Uncertainty (Task Uncertainty with boundary spanning-internal:  $r = .38, p < .05$ ; with boundary spanning-external:  $r = .39, p < .05$ ; and with Boundary Spanning-Total:  $r = .46, p < .02$ ). Finally, Professional Activity was significantly related to both Perceived Role Specification ( $r = .73, p < .001$ ) and Professional Training ( $r = .44, p < .05$ ). None of the boundary spanning variables were related significantly to Environmental Uncertainty, Role Specification, Professional Training or Activities, or District Size or Wealth.

TABLE 1  
Means and Standard Deviations for the BSQ as Completed by the 27 Responding School Psychologists

| <i>BSQ Variables</i>                | <i>Mean</i> | <i>Standard Deviation</i> | <i>Range</i> |
|-------------------------------------|-------------|---------------------------|--------------|
| Boundary spanning-internal          | 20.70       | 13.34                     | 0-72         |
| Boundary spanning-external          | 8.89        | 6.33                      | 0-72         |
| Boundary Spanning-Total             | 29.59       | 17.56                     | 0-144        |
| Perceived Environmental Uncertainty | 2.89        | .43                       | 9-45         |
| Perceived Task Uncertainty          | 2.79        | .38                       | 9-45         |
| Perceived Role Specification        | 2.48        | .75                       | 4-20         |
| Professionalism-Total               | 82.04       | 44.70                     | 30-120       |
| Professionalism-Activities          | 8.96        | 4.15                      | 0-25         |
| Size of District <sup>a</sup>       | 4,841       | 3,168                     |              |
| Wealth of District <sup>b</sup>     | \$74,529.15 | \$20,645.39               |              |

<sup>a</sup>Based on student enrollment. <sup>b</sup>Based on a full valuation to resident weighted average daily attendance ratio.

TABLE 2  
Pearson Correlation Coefficients for the 10 Variables Assessed by the Boundary Spanning Questionnaire<sup>a</sup>

|      | BSAI   | BSAE   | BSAT | PEU | TU   | SPC    | PROT | PROA | SIZE |
|------|--------|--------|------|-----|------|--------|------|------|------|
| BSAE | .53**  |        |      |     |      |        |      |      |      |
| BSAT | .91*** | .72*** |      |     |      |        |      |      |      |
| PEU  | .34    | .21    | .30  |     |      |        |      |      |      |
| TU   | .38*   | .39*   | .46* | .27 |      |        |      |      |      |
| SPC  | -.13   | -.25   | -.15 | .13 | -.20 |        |      |      |      |
| PROT | -.07   | .10    | .09  | .08 | .15  | .20    |      |      |      |
| PROA | -.13   | -.20   | -.14 | .21 | -.05 | .73*** | .44* |      |      |
| SIZE | .29    | .10    | .34  | .17 | -.09 | .10    | .28  | -.02 |      |
| WLT  | .27    | .01    | .16  | .11 | .08  | -.00   | .08  | .24  | .21  |

Note. BSAI = Boundary spanning-internal; BSAE = Boundary spanning-external; BSAT = Boundary Spanning-Total; PEU = Perceived Environmental Uncertainty; TU = Task Uncertainty; SPC = Perceived Role Specification; PROT = Professionalism-Training; PROA = Professionalism-Activities; SIZE = Size of District; WLT = Wealth of District.

<sup>a</sup>N = 27.

\* $p < .05$ . \*\* $p < .01$ . \*\*\* $p < .001$ .

## DISCUSSION

The purpose of this study was to investigate school psychologists' consultative boundary spanning activities within the context of the special education multidisciplinary team and to assess the relation of those activities to a number of organizational and team-specific variables. Correlational analyses indicated that boundary spanning-internal, -external, and -total were all positively correlated together; that these three boundary spanning components were all positively correlated to task uncertainty; and that the school psychologists' composite professional activities were positively correlated to their professional training and perceived role specification. Significantly, this study did not replicate Jerrell's (1984) research that found a relation between boundary spanning and environmental uncertainty.

The results of these analyses suggest that consultative boundary spanning activities within the school, outside of the school into the community, and overall increased as task uncertainty increased. That is, the school psychologists in the New York sample initiated more communication and formal contacts about their multidisciplinary team and case-specific responsibilities when they perceived their responsibilities as unpredictable, difficult, and/or nonroutine. Theoretically, this result is consistent with the organizational psychology literature (Galbraith, 1977) that suggests that decision makers will design information-

gathering strategies when faced with insufficient task or process information (i.e., uncertainty). Functionally, this result is necessary as school psychologists work to eliminate all areas of uncertainty before making critical educational and mental health decisions on behalf of referred students.

Faced with task uncertainty, then, it seems logical and necessary for school psychologists to increase their consultative boundary spanning activities. Functionally, these boundary spanning activities provide both informational and professional support, and they result in greater job satisfaction and perceptions of increased influence within the school and community systems (Jerrell, 1984). More preventively, however, the specific sources of task uncertainty within MDTs need further study. These sources may involve professional, MDT, school system, and state- or federally-legislated task uncertainties, and they may be case-specific (i.e., related to a referred child) or process-specific (i.e., relating to the special education decision making or program planning process). Future research must investigate whether school psychologists are confronted with certain consistent sources of task uncertainty that will always necessitate increased consultation and boundary spanning activities or whether they must continually react to unexpected and unplanned task uncertainties that require strategic boundary spanning activity and management. Whereas boundary spanning activities potentially expand school psychologists' knowledge, skill, objectivity, and, perhaps most critically, their ability to maintain a balanced perspective when persistent uncertainty leads to professional and personal crisis and burn-out, the identification of typical and atypical task uncertainties might result in the development of effective and efficient boundary spanning strategies and responses.

As to the other significant relations in the correlational analysis, the interrelations between the boundary spanning-internal, -external, and -total items were anticipated, and they lend further construct validity to the BSQ. The significant correlations between the Professional Activity variable and the Perceived Role Specification and Professional Training variables, respectively, suggest that the New York school psychologists' understanding of their MDT roles and activities positively related to their participation in continuing education activities and their membership in professional associations and that these continuing education and professional association activities positively related to each psychologist's formal graduate training. Although a causal and directional relationship cannot be determined by this study, future research might confirm that increased continuing education can help school psychologists to better understand and perform their roles and responsibilities within MDTs and special education and that ad-

vanced degree school psychologists are more apt to participate in continuing education than entry-level practitioners.

Among the nonsignificant correlations in this study, the most important was the lack of a relation between boundary spanning activity and environmental uncertainty, one that was significant in Jerrell's (1984) study. Reasons for this lack of replication might include (a) differences in the environmental characteristics between the small city districts in the present study and the rural Pennsylvania districts in Jerrell's study; (b) differences in how the boundary spanning and/or environmental uncertainty questions on the respective surveys were interpreted and responded to by individuals in the two studies; (c) differences in the school psychologists' functional roles in New York versus Pennsylvania; and (d) the fact that this study investigated school psychologists' multidisciplinary team roles, whereas the Jerrell study investigated school psychologists' comprehensive, full-time roles in the schools. Whatever the reason, future research needs to investigate these two variables more closely to differentiate their relation to each other and to other professional and special education functions and processes. Future research also needs to investigate the boundary spanning activities of other multidisciplinary team professionals to determine whether their activities have similar relations to the variables investigated in this study.

Although a number of future research directions have been previously suggested, the limitations of this study and the need for conservative interpretation must be emphasized. This study was completed in New York State, and, although many school districts were represented, it may be that this state's special education philosophies, laws, and procedures significantly influenced the results. The results, therefore, must be considered in this context, and future research should investigate these same variables in states with different special education practices to determine if they generalize across settings. Similarly, the sample consisted only of small city school districts, and none of the participating school psychologists had doctoral degrees. This research, therefore, needs to be conducted with small, rural, and large city or metropolitan school districts to determine generalization across settings and to involve a larger number of school psychologists who are trained at both the nondoctoral and doctoral levels to determine the relation, if any, between boundary spanning activity and training. Finally, this research was questionnaire-bound, dependent on the recall and accuracy of the respondent. Future research should evaluate boundary spanning *in situ* so that the present results, their directionality, and other possible variables can be validated and further differentiated.

For the present, this study has added to the empirical research

investigating school psychologists' consultative boundary spanning activities and their related organizational group process and perceptual variables. It has provided additional insight into the boundary spanning process and has introduced a methodology for further use and investigation. Hopefully, others will increase their research activity in this area, thereby increasing our knowledge of the underlying processes inherent in meeting the responsibilities of the MDT mandate and in performing the comprehensive activities that make up school psychological services.

### ACKNOWLEDGMENT

George H. Amedore is now at South Glens Fall Central Schools, South Glens Falls, New York.

### REFERENCES

- Aldrich, H., & Herker, D. (1977). Boundary spanning roles and organization structure. *Academy of Management Review*, 2, 217-230.
- Downey, K., & Slocum, J. (1975). Uncertainty: Measures, research, and sources of variation. *Academy of Management Journal*, 18, 562-578.
- Galbraith, J. (1977). *Organizational design*. Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley.
- Goldwasser, E., Meyers, J., Christenson, S., & Graden, J. (1983). The impact of PL 94-142 on the practice of school psychology. *Psychology in the Schools*, 20, 153-165.
- Hage, J., & Aiken, M. (1967). Relationship of centralization to other structural properties. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 12, 72-92.
- Hughes, J. N. (1979). Consistency of administrators' and psychologists' actual and ideal perceptions of school psychologists' activities. *Psychology in the Schools*, 16, 234-239.
- Illback, R. J., & Maher, C. A. (1984). The school psychologist as an organizational boundary role professional. *Journal of School Psychology*, 22, 63-72.
- Jerrell, J. M. (1984). Boundary-spanning functions served by rural school psychologists. *Journal of School Psychology*, 22, 259-271.
- Kahl, L. J., & Fine, M. J. (1978). Teachers' perceptions of the school psychologist as a function of teaching experience, amount of contact, and socioeconomic status of the school. *Psychology in the Schools*, 15, 577-582.
- Kaiser, S. M., & Woodman, R. W. (1985). Multidisciplinary teams and group decision-making techniques: Possible solutions to decision-making problems. *School Psychology Review*, 14, 457-470.
- Katz, D., & Kahn, R. L. (1978). *The social psychology of organizations* (2nd ed.). New York: Wiley.
- Knoff, H. M. (1983). Investigating disproportionate influence and status in multidisciplinary child study teams. *Exceptional Children*, 49, 367-370.
- Knoff, H. M., & Batsche, G. M. (1990). The place of the school in community mental health services for children: A necessary interdependence. *The Journal of Mental Health Administration*, 17, 122-130.
- Leifer, R. (1975). *An analysis of the characteristics and functioning of boundary spanning personnel*. Unpublished doctoral dissertation, University of Wisconsin-Madison.



- Leifer, R., & Delbecq, R. (1978). Organizational/environmental interchange: A model of boundary spanning activity. *Academy of Management Review*, 3, 40-50.
- Leifer, R., & Huber, G. (1977). Relations among perceived environmental uncertainty, organizational structure, and boundary spanning behavior. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 22, 235-247.
- Maher, C. A., & Pfeiffer, S. I. (1983). Multidisciplinary teams in the schools: Perspectives, practices, possibilities. *School Psychology Review*, 12, 123-189.
- Schmuck, R. A. (1990). Organizational development in the schools: Contemporary concepts and practices. In T. B. Gutkin & C. R. Reynolds (Eds.), *The handbook of school psychology* (2nd ed., pp. 901-921). New York: Wiley.
- Schowengert, R. V., Fine, M. J., & Poggio, J. P. (1976). An examination of some bases of teacher satisfaction with school psychological services. *Psychology in the Schools*, 13, 269-275.
- Senft, L. B., & Snider, B. (1980). Elementary school principals assess services of school psychologists nationwide. *Journal of School Psychology*, 18, 276-282.
- Smith, D. K. (1984). Practicing school psychologists: Their characteristics, activities, and populations served. *Professional Psychology: Research and Practice*, 15, 798-810.
- Tushman, M., & Scanlan, T. (1981). Boundary spanning individuals: Their role in information transfer and their antecedents. *Academy of Management Journal*, 24, 289-305.
- Van De Ven, A., & Ferry, D. (1980). *Measuring and addressing organizations*. New York: Wiley.
- Wallace, G. (1976). Interdisciplinary efforts in learning disabilities: Issues and recommendations. *Journal of Learning Disabilities*, 9, 59-65.
- Yoshida, R. K. (1983). Are multidisciplinary teams worth the investment? *School Psychology Review*, 12, 137-143.
- Yoshida, R. K., Fenton, K. S., Maxwell, J. P., & Kaufman, M. J. (1978). Group decision making in the planning team: Myth or reality? *Journal of School Psychology*, 16, 237-244.
- Yoshida, R. K., Maher, C. A., & Hawryluk, M. K. (1984). School psychology practice: Organizational barriers to professional attainment. *Professional Psychology: Research and Practice*, 15, 571-578.